

Zitian Wang

University of Virginia
Department of Economics
248 McCormick Rd,
Charlottesville, VA 22904

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Email: zw3qt@virginia.edu
Phone: +1 434-466-0957
Homepage: <https://zitianwang96.github.io/>

Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Virginia 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation: “Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment”

Committee: Charles Holt, Po-Hsuan Lin, Peter Troyan, Noah Myung

M.A. in Economics, Columbia University 2019 – 2020

B.A. in Economics and B.S. in Financial Mathematics, University of California, Los Angeles 2015 – 2019

Research Fields

Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization

Job Market Paper

1. **Wang, Z.** (2026) “Auction for Prominence and Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment”

Working Papers

2. **Wang, Z.**, Ahmed, I., Unjitwattana, P., Xie, E.Y., Fong, M.-J. & Lin, P.-H. (2026) “[Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games](#)” (**First author**). Revising at **European Economic Review**.
3. **Wang, Z.** (2025) “[Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game](#)” [[Slides](#)]

Conference, Seminar and Workshop Presentations

2026 Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meeting*, ESA World Meeting,
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting*, BEEMA10,
UVA Theory/Experimental Student Workshop

2025 ESA North American Meeting, BEEMA9

(* scheduled)

Grants and Awards

Director of Graduate Studies Research Grant (US\$2,000), University of Virginia 2026

Graduate School of Arts & Sciences Council Grant (US\$500), University of Virginia 2026

Travel Grant, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (US\$400), Duke University 2026

Professional Activities

Organizer

UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop	2025 – Present
UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Reading Group	2025 – Present

Research Experience

Research assistant for Prof. Peter Troyan, University of Virginia	2026
Research assistant for Prof. Denis Nekipelov, University of Virginia	2023

Summer School Attendance

Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory, Northwestern University	2026
Behavioral Game Theory Summer School, University of East Anglia	2026
Chicago School in Experimental Economics, University of Chicago	2024

Teaching

Instructor, University of Virginia

Intermediate Macroeconomics (evaluation: 4.6/5)	Fall 2025, Spring 2026
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Teaching Assistant, University of Virginia

Principles of Microeconomics	Fall 2022
Principles of Macroeconomics	Spring 2023
Intermediate Macroeconomics	Fall 2023
Intermediate Microeconomics	Spring 2024
Global Financial Markets	Fall 2024, Fall 2025
Economics of Risk, Uncertainty, and Information	Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant, Columbia University

Principles of Economics	Summer 2020
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Skills

Programming: Python, oTree, Stata, MATLAB, L^AT_EX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript

Languages: Chinese (native), English (near-native)

Certificate: CFA Level I

References

Charles Holt

Department of Economics
University of Virginia
holt@virginia.edu

Peter Troyan

Department of Economics
University of Virginia
pgt8y@virginia.edu

Po-Hsuan Lin

Department of Economics
University of Virginia
plin@virginia.edu

Ana Fostel

Department of Economics
University of Virginia
alf8p@virginia.edu

Abstracts

1. Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment

We develop a parsimonious model of search prominence and test its predictions in a controlled laboratory experiment varying the strength of the search friction. Two sellers bid in a second-price auction for a prominent position that gives the winner a search-cost advantage. Sellers then post prices simultaneously. Observing the two prices and the top seller’s match value for free, the buyer decides whether to pay a sunk cost to inspect the second seller’s match value. The experiment confirms the theory’s central prediction: the top seller prices higher than the second seller, and this gap widens as prominence grows, indicating that prominence confers market power. However, behavior departs from theory in several ways. Prices are more dispersed than predicted, compressing the price gap and reshaping how buyers search. Under strong prominence, this price-induced search keeps buyers loyal to the top seller and lifts its profit above the competitive benchmark. Under weak prominence, sellers overbid so severely for the position that their profits fall below the predicted level. While buyers over- and under-search, their behavior remains close to optimal on average, allowing them to capture more surplus than predicted. These welfare anomalies stem mainly from the distorted prices that prominence induces, rather than from noisy search alone.

2. Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games

How level-0 players behave and how they are perceived by higher-level players are central questions in the literature on level-k models of boundedly rational strategic reasoning. To study these twin questions, we apply the intra-team communication method developed by Burchardi and Penczynski (2014) to identify level-0 actions and beliefs in the canonical beauty contest game and in a variant of the 11–20 game of Goeree et al. (2018), in which behavior appears inconsistent with the standard level-k model. In the beauty contest game, we replicate Burchardi and Penczynski (2014)’s finding that elicited level-0 beliefs align with observed level-0 actions. In the variant of the 11–20 game, however, elicited level-0 beliefs and observed level-0 actions diverge, and both depart from the standard level-0 assumption, suggesting a complementary explanation for the behavioral pattern documented by Goeree et al. (2018).

3. Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game

Which information transmission protocols improve coordination under uncertainty and noisy communication? Theory is indeterminate between an inefficient “tacit” equilibrium, where information is ignored, and an efficient “vocal” equilibrium, where players act on it. We test this in a laboratory experiment based on a generalized email game, exogenously varying the message-generation rule across three protocols. Vocal behavior rises with the incentive to take the risky action, and relative to an automatic protocol, voluntary messaging significantly improves coordination. However, a sunk cost to sending reduces vocalicity by inducing senders to opt out. These patterns suggest that voluntariness credibly signals players’ intent to coordinate via forward induction, and that the value of cost-free signaling for equilibrium selection hinges on the alignment of interests.